

Home Affairs Committee

Police response to the 2024 summer disorder: Government Response

First Special Report of Session 2024–25

HC 1099

Home Affairs Committee

The Home Affairs Committee is appointed by the House of Commons to examine the expenditure, administration, and policy of the Home Office and its associated public bodies.

Current membership

[Dame Karen Bradley](#) (Conservative; Staffordshire Moorlands) (Chair)

[Shaun Davies](#) (Labour; Telford)

[Mr Paul Kohler](#) (Liberal Democrat; Wimbledon)

[Ben Maguire](#) (Liberal Democrat; North Cornwall)

[Robbie Moore](#) (Conservative; Keighley and Ilkley)

[Margaret Mullane](#) (Labour; Dagenham and Rainham)

[Chris Murray](#) (Labour; Edinburgh East and Musselburgh)

[Mr Connor Rand](#) (Labour; Altrincham and Sale West)

[Joani Reid](#) (Labour; East Kilbride and Strathaven)

[Bell Ribeiro-Addy](#) (Labour; Clapham and Brixton Hill)

[Jake Richards](#) (Labour; Rother Valley)

Powers

The Committee is one of the departmental select committees, the powers of which are set out in House of Commons Standing Orders, principally in SO No. 152. These are available on the internet via www.parliament.uk.

Publication

This Special Report, was Ordered by the House of Commons, on 1 July 2025, to be printed. It was published on 3 July 2025 by authority of the House of Commons. © Parliamentary Copyright House of Commons 2025.

This publication may be reproduced under the terms of the Open Parliament Licence, which is published at www.parliament.uk/copyright.

Committee reports are published on the Committee's website at www.parliament.uk/homeaffairscom and in print by Order of the House.

Contacts

All correspondence should be addressed to the Clerk of the Home Affairs Committee, House of Commons, London SW1A 0AA. The telephone number for general enquiries is 020 7219 3440; the Committee's email address is homeaffcom@parliament.uk. You can follow the Committee on X (formerly Twitter) using [@CommonsHomeAffs](https://twitter.com/CommonsHomeAffs).

First Special Report

The Home Affairs Committee published its Second Report of Session 2024–25, [Police response to the 2024 summer disorder](#) (HC 381) on 14 April 2025. The Government response was received on 18 June 2025, and is appended below.

Appendix: Government Response

Introduction

The scenes of violent disorder witnessed during the summer were deeply disturbing. Police officers across the country demonstrated exceptional leadership and bravery in quelling the violent disorder. The co-ordinated public order response between police forces across the country was vital to showing that the criminals responsible for that violence would not get away with it. However, this was the result of the exemplary leadership and partnership shown by police leaders that operated in spite of, not because of, the systems in place, and the Government is keen to ensure policing have the necessary tools and resources that it needs to deal with any future disorder.

Recommendations

1. Social media mis- and disinformation

Recommendation: Notwithstanding potential changes to contempt of court laws, we recommend that the CPS publish its new media protocol as soon as possible and keep this updated at least every five years or earlier if there is a significant change to the media landscape. It should also work with partner organisations in the police and media to ensure there is a clear shared understanding of its interpretation and use.

Response:

The CPS supported the committee to scrutinise the process by which information was shared with the public following the appalling attack in Southport last year.

The Media Protocol is a joint agreement with CPS, policing and the media which provides guidance for how prosecution material in criminal trial proceedings is shared with the media.

The CPS is currently reviewing and updating the protocol with policing and media to ensure it takes account of changes to legislation, policy and the media landscape to clearly set out what information or prosecution material can be released to the media. This work began before the 2024 summer disorder began. A public consultation seeking views on a revised draft Media Protocol and User Guidance was launched in January 2025 and closed in March 2025. This is now in the process of reviewing all the responses we received and working with partners to agree an updated version of the protocol. The intention is to publish the revised media protocol and user guidance in autumn, alongside a summary of the consultation responses, with supporting training and communication to ensure there is a clear understanding of the protocol and its use. The protocol will be kept under joint review.

Alongside this, the CPS supports proposals for law reform which will make the application of contempt law clearer and simpler – especially when linked to heightened matters of general public interest such as public safety or national security. The CPS has responded to the Law Commission's supplementary consultation in full.

2. Policing response to the disorder

Recommendation: We recommend that the Government publishes a formal response, after the second tranche of the HMICFRS review is published, setting out how it will support police forces to implement the findings of the review, including any additional funding if required, and over what timeframe.

Response:

It is important that we learn the lessons from the most significant public disorder in more than a decade. The Government and police are now carefully considering the recommendations made by the Inspectorate as well as the recommendations made in the Committee's own report.

The Government's Police Reform White Paper will set out how it intends to address the findings from the Inspectorate and the Committee, and the wider system reform needed in policing. This White Paper reflects the

Government's commitment to learning the lessons of the disorder, and will include proposals to strengthen Public Order Policing and enhance the longer-term cross-system response to violent disorder.

PCCs must also, as the elected voice of the people, hold their Chief Constable to account for individual forces' implementation of the recommendations in HMICFRS' inspection report. Each PCC must also respond to HMICFRS' report within 56 days of its publication.

Recommendation: The new national system for policing should include enhanced capacity to monitor and respond to social media at the national level, while also supporting forces to develop the necessary capacity.

Response:

The Home Office and its Agencies has and continues to use open-source material to good effect to support a range of missions. This has included support to tackle illegal migration operations and associated organised crime along with support to crisis management response.

We have considered plans to strengthen this capability to protect the public and this includes consideration of a range of options including a more centralised approach. We have worked both internally with partners and the tech sector on specific proposals which will require financial investment.

Decisions have not been taken on the form that stronger open source capability may take and proposals will continue to be considered. All options are being considered to ensure that government has the appropriate information to fulfil our public duties, and we will always consider maximising effectiveness and efficiency by bringing capabilities and people together.

Recommendation: As part of a formal response to the HMICFRS reports the Government should set out in particular how it is supporting forces to improve the provision of mutual aid, including how changes to the national policing system will support it.

Response:

We are working with the police to ensure measures for the Police System Reform White Paper are suitably designed to tackle the policing challenges of the future. Separately, and focused specifically on their response to public order, the police have reviewed the national mobilisation plan, which now specifically describes the national public order gold role, who has explicit authority to decide on national mobilisation numbers and to set the strategic plan that forces should follow ('tier 4' mobilisation). The plan

has been agreed at Chief's Councils and circulated amongst forces. The Government will reflect on how these changes can be built upon in the Police Reform White Paper.

3. National policing response

Recommendation: Given the importance of the Government's ambitions on crime and policing, including halving knife crime and halving Violence Against Women and Girls, and the significant challenges facing the policing system, we encourage the Government to be ambitious in setting out its proposals for reform and not just focus on easy, short-term wins.

Response:

The Government has set out an unprecedented objective of halving the levels of Violence Against Women and Girls (VAWG) in a decade. We will deliver a cross-Government transformative approach, underpinned by a new Strategy to be published later this year based on the best possible evidence, both in the UK and internationally.

The new VAWG Strategy will set out the strategic direction and concrete actions to pursue the Government's ambition to halve VAWG in a decade. It will take a long-term approach to addressing systemic issues over 10 years with prevention and education being fundamental to the approach. We will use every tool available to target perpetrators and expect to see sustained work across policing to drive up standards and to ensure there is always a swift and specialist response to these appalling crimes. The Home Office have already announced £13.1 million funding for a new National Centre for VAWG and Public Protection (NCVPP) to improve the national coordination and response to violence against women and girls and child sexual abuse. The Centre was launched in April 2025 to enable policing to better target these crimes.

However, as set out in the Plan for Change, the Safer Streets Mission to halve knife crime, half violence against women and girls and restore the public's confidence in policing cannot be achieved through further investment alone. We need to set up the policing system to succeed in the long-term and address systemic issues so that policing can better deliver for the public.

The Home Office's White Paper on policing reform will set out a significant and ambitious package of reforms to policing in England and Wales that will drive quality, consistency and efficiency and ensure that all police forces are equipped to deliver the Government's Safer Streets Mission and Plan for Change.

As part of this bold new approach, the Home Office set up a Joint Police Reform Team. This brings together expertise from the Home Office, APCC, and NPCC. It is co-producing policy, shaping reform priorities, and ensuring joint decision-making to deliver meaningful and lasting change.

The reset reflects a commitment to stronger partnership working between policing and Government. The Home Secretary has made clear that effective policing cannot happen in isolation – it requires collaboration, shared priorities, and targeted support where Government can add value, such as prevention programmes and workforce development.

4. Impact on police forces

Recommendation: The Government should outline a comprehensive strategy for police officer retention alongside its recruitment efforts.

Response:

We are looking to develop reforms to the workforce as part of the forthcoming Police Reform White Paper. This will include activity designed to support the retention of police officers and to support them through their careers. This Government recognises the importance of recruiting the right candidates into policing and retaining skilled and experienced officers.

The retention of police officers is a priority for the Home Office and the National Police Chiefs' Council. Voluntary resignation rates in England and Wales, at 3.4%, are low compared to other sectors. The latest Home Office survey of new recruits carried out in 2023 (receiving a total of 3,556 responses) found that 85% of respondents were satisfied with their job, 72% intend to stay in their role until retirement age. Experienced officers are incredibly valuable, which is why forces should be using effective, evidence-based strategies to manage retention and progression of existing officers in addition to focussing on high quality recruitment processes to recruit new officers.

Decisions about police recruitment, including how recruitment and selection processes are run, are a matter for Chief Constables and Police and Crime Commissioners and are therefore managed locally by forces. This is done within a national application, assessment and selection framework, in line with national guidance maintained by the College.

The College of Policing also provides a learning platform for all forces that contains learning, insights and guidance themed around Attraction, Recruitment, Onboarding and Retention. Forces should be accessing this learning to support recruitment and retention activity.

A specific focus on retention is also being delivered through the NPCC National Leavers Framework (NLF). The NLF promotes the use of standard data collection and consistent processes across forces, including Stay Interviews and Exit interviews. Forces applying these standards and collect data via the framework, establishes an evidence base which can increase understanding of the reasons why officers are leaving. This will enable forces to put measures in place to improve retention. With the additional adoption of Stay Interviews, there are opportunities to also improve support for officers to remain in policing and improve morale.

Recommendation: If it has not done so already the Government should release funding to cover costs incurred during the disorder as soon as possible.

Response:

The Home Secretary has agreed to provide police forces in England and Wales with £28.3 million of funding to cover all of the additional costs of policing the disorder. This funding was paid in full in May 2025.

Recommendation: The Government should benchmark recruitment plans under the Neighbourhood Policing Guarantee to ensure that, while flexibility for forces to recruit is maintained, minimum numbers for the recruitment of police officers can be set by the Home Office if required, or more flexibility in funding provided if forces cannot meet their staffing needs through the Neighbourhood Policing Guarantee.

Response:

For the purposes of funding and conditions for the neighbourhood policing programme, the local base for each force is set as at March 2025. We have been working closely with policing to develop the neighbourhood policing programme. Our approach to delivery in 2025/26, which is year 1 of a multiple year programme across parliament, is designed to deliver an initial increase to the neighbourhood policing workforce in a manner that is flexible and can be adapted to the local context and varied crime demands.

Whilst the precise workforce mix proposed is a local decision, we expect forces to approach delivery in a way that is locally suitable and effectively contributes to the manifesto commitment of delivering a 13,000 increase by the end of this parliament. An assessment of progress and learnings from year 1 of delivery will be used to inform delivery models for future phases of the programme.

With regard to preserving the total number of officers across all policing functions, the Government is committed to ensuring police forces are supported to tackle crime effectively. Visible policing is essential to restoring public confidence in the police. As a result, the Government's expectation is that officer numbers must be protected in 2025–26.

For 2025–26, £376.8 million will be available to forces to maintain officer numbers. This funding will be distributed as follows:

- £270.1 million will be ringfenced funding, which PCCs will be able to access, as in previous years, by demonstrating that they have maintained their officer numbers.
- £106.7 million will be paid to forces who have received additional recruitment allocations in 2024–25 and 2025–26. This funding will be provided as an additional recruitment top up grant. It will be unconditional, and the funding distributed according to how much additional recruitment forces have carried out.

Decisions in officer maintenance and funding for future years beyond 2025–26 will be set out in the upcoming Spending Review. It is for Chief Constables and directly elected PCCs, and Mayors with PCC functions, to make decisions, including how best to allocate all the resources at their disposal.

5. The political response

Recommendation: The Government should ensure that its policing reforms empower the national policing system to respond effectively to emergency situations, without requiring significant Government intervention.

Response:

Although officers demonstrated exceptional bravery last summer, the police were limited by the systems available to them. The police, and the public they serve, need a system that is fit for purpose and fit for the future. The Home Office's White Paper on police reform will cover issues from technology to the future workforce, from how the policing system can work better to tackle fast changing crime, to leadership and culture. The Home Secretary has been clear that she will work with policing in partnership to address the existing challenges and help the system deliver effective and efficient policing to the public.